

A MRGE MARKETING REPORT

The State of B2B Marketing in Canada

What's working right now in Canadian B2B marketing and what every growth-focused Founder, CEO and Marketing Leads need to prepare for before the end of the year.

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About this report

We are halfway through 2026. The Canadian B2B marketing landscape has shifted more in the past eighteen months than in the five years prior. The second half of this year is shaping up to be a pivotal test of which companies have built real marketing infrastructure and which ones are still running on momentum and hope.

This report combines verified third-party research with direct observations from mrge Marketing's work with Canadian B2B professional services and technology companies. Where data is Canada-specific, it is clearly identified. Where global research is applied to the Canadian context, we have noted its origin and relevance.

We have not invented, extrapolated, or rounded numbers for effect. Every figure cited has a named source. Our first-person observations, drawn from active client engagements, are clearly marked as such; included because they reflect patterns we see consistently across the market, not anecdotes selected to support a predetermined conclusion.

WHO THIS REPORT IS FOR

This report is written for **CEOs, founders, and senior leaders at Canadian B2B companies**, primarily in professional services and technology, who are trying to decide how to allocate their marketing investment in the second half of 2026. It is also written for marketing leaders who need to make the case internally for why marketing deserves both a seat at the executive table and a budget that reflects its role in revenue growth.

If your company is between **\$5M and \$100M in revenue** and you have ever felt like your marketing is busy but not moving the needle, this report is for you.

2026 is the year the bill comes due.

Canadian B2B companies spent 2024 and 2025 experimenting with AI, launching new channels, and convincing themselves that activity was the same as strategy. Now, with budgets tightening, economic headwinds lengthening sales cycles, and buyers more self-directed than ever, the question is no longer whether you are doing marketing. **It is whether your marketing is actually driving revenue.**

The companies that will finish 2026 ahead of where they started have one thing in common: they stopped running campaigns and started building systems. They have a defined ideal customer, a consistent presence in the channels their buyers use, a way to measure what is working, and someone accountable for the outcome.

The companies that will struggle are still on the **Campaign Treadmill**: active on three social channels, posting intermittently, spending on tactics they cannot attribute, and unable to answer the question their CFO is now asking: *where did the leads come from?*

Five things this report found

1

Budgets are tightening, but the mandate is to spend smarter, not less.

Companies that can demonstrate marketing ROI will protect and grow their budgets. Companies that cannot will face cuts.

2

AI is nearly universal, but most companies can't tell if it's helping.

The gap is not adoption, it's strategy. Using AI without a measurement framework produces activity, not results.

3

Cold outreach is broken in its traditional form.

Volume-based cold email and LinkedIn DM campaigns show diminishing returns. Winners lead with genuine value and surgical targeting.

4

Account-Based Marketing is delivering the fastest measurable returns.

A well-executed ABM program, multi-channel, with vertical-specific offers, is the most reliable path to new revenue this year.

5

Marketing leadership + AI-assisted execution is the emerging team model.

As AI reshapes how work gets done, fractional leadership is rising to meet the moment — giving companies senior expertise and volume capacity without the full-time cost. A leader who knows what great looks like, supported by AI and the right team, is the model that wins.

01 Where the Canadian B2B market stands in 2026

Canada's digital advertising market crossed the \$21 billion threshold in 2025, marking a sustained period of double-digit growth that has continued into 2026. But the headline number obscures a more important story: growth in the overall market **has not translated into proportional growth in pipeline** for most Canadian B2B companies.

The reasons are structural. Digital ad budgets are increasingly concentrated in a few platforms, primarily Google and Meta, and dominated by B2C advertisers with larger budgets and shorter conversion cycles. For B2B companies in professional services and technology, **organic presence and earned attention have become more valuable**, not less, as paid costs rise.

\$21B+

Canadian digital ad market, now a baseline, not a milestone.

IAB CANADA · 2025 INTERNET ADVERTISING REVENUE FORECAST

At the same time, Canada's economic environment has created a buyer-behaviour shift most marketing teams have not fully adjusted to. Sales cycles are longer. Approval processes involve more stakeholders. Buyers conduct more due diligence independently before engaging vendors and that research increasingly begins with **AI-assisted tools** rather than a Google search.

The tightening budget reality

The most consistent signal we hear from Canadian B2B leaders entering H2 2026 is budget scrutiny. Not across-the-board cuts, but a demand for accountability that many marketing teams are not equipped to meet. The CFO question being asked in boardrooms across Canada is direct: **show me where the marketing spend is generating return.**

This is not new. But tolerance for vague answers, impressions, reach, brand awareness, has shortened considerably. Companies that built measurement infrastructure in 2024 and 2025 are in a strong position. Companies that did not are facing a difficult conversation.



The companies we work with that are growing confidently in 2026 are not necessarily spending more on marketing. They are spending more deliberately and they can tell you what their dollars are doing.

Melissa Gallo • Founder & CEO, mrge Marketing

For Canadian B2B companies in the \$5M–\$100M range, the implication is straightforward: marketing investment needs to be traceable to pipeline and revenue. Not eventually, **now.** Building the measurement foundation is no longer optional.

02 The Canadian B2B buyer in 2026

The B2B buying journey has fundamentally reorganized around the buyer's preferred timeline, not the vendor's. Gartner found that **61% of B2B buyers now prefer an overall rep-free buying experience**. That statistic was startling when published. In 2026, it is the baseline.

61%

of B2B buyers prefer a rep-free buying experience

GARTNER · 2025

94%

now use AI tools at some point in their purchasing process

GARTNER B2B BUYER RESEARCH · 2025

By the time a prospect reaches out, they have already done the majority of their evaluation. They have read your content, or your competitor's. They have looked at your LinkedIn. They may have asked ChatGPT, Claude or Perplexity which firms are worth talking to. The first conversation is no longer the beginning of the sales process. **It is closer to the end.**

Two implications many companies have not absorbed: first, the quality of your digital presence is now a **hard filter**, a weak website, an inactive LinkedIn, and no thought leadership means you are eliminated before you know a prospect existed. Second, the value of genuine, expert, experience-backed content has never been higher.

The AI-assisted research shift

A significant change taking shape in 2026 is the role of AI in the buyer's research process.

B2B buyers at all levels now use tools like ChatGPT, Perplexity, Claude, and Microsoft Copilot to shortlist vendors, understand category options, and pressure-test the claims companies make about themselves.

This is both a threat and an opportunity. **The threat:** if your content is thin or generic, you may not appear in AI-assisted research at all. **The opportunity:** companies that publish specific, credible, experience-backed content are increasingly surfaced by AI tools as recommended resources, appearing in a buyer's consideration set before any direct contact occurs.

This emerging discipline, Answer Engine Optimization (AEO) or Generative Engine Optimization (GEO), is not separate from good content strategy. It is the natural extension of it. The same content that earns trust from human readers is what AI tools surface as reliable references.

71%

Millennials and Gen Z now represent **71% of B2B buyers** — with higher expectations for vendor credibility, digital presence, and value-led engagement.

THEY DO NOT RESPOND TO COLD OUTREACH. THEY RESPOND TO CONTENT THAT HELPS THEM THINK.

The implication for Canadian B2B companies is concrete: **your buyers are researching you before they contact you, using tools that reward depth and specificity over volume.** A company with twelve well-researched articles on its category, a founder who publishes genuine perspective on LinkedIn, and a website that clearly articulates who it serves and how, that company shows up. A company with a brochure website and a blog that hasn't been updated in eight months does not.

03 The AI reality check for Canadian B2B

AI adoption among Canadian businesses has doubled in twelve months. Statistics Canada shows 12.2% of businesses now use AI to produce goods or deliver services, up from 6.1% a year earlier. Among professional and technical services firms, where most mrge Marketing's clients operate, adoption sits at **31.7%**.

2x

Growth in Canadian business AI adoption in 12 months.

STATISTICS CANADA · Q2 2025

71%

of Canadian SMBs are now actively using AI tools.

MICROSOFT CANADA · 2025 (300 SMB DECISION-MAKERS)

The problem: Using AI without a strategy

The most consistent observation we make across new engagements in 2026: **companies are using AI, but they cannot tell you if it's helping.** They generate more content, more posts, more drafts, more outlines. But without measurement, attribution, and a strategy that connects output to buyer behaviour and pipeline, **more content is just more noise.**

The issue is not AI itself. It is the sequence. Most companies adopted AI before they had a clear ICP, a documented content strategy, or a measurement system, layering a productivity tool on top of an undefined process and expecting the output to improve.

The companies generating genuine return from AI are using it as an execution layer on top of a defined strategy, not as a substitute for one. They also understand something the others have missed: when everyone is using AI to produce content, **the differentiator is brand and knowing what great looks like**. Without that standard, AI produces competent content that sounds like everyone else's competent content.

The sequence that works

1

Define your ICP and the problems they're solving.

AI can't do this alone, it requires the accumulated knowledge of your team and client experience.

2

Define your brand voice.

A distinct point of view and a recognizable tone are what prevent AI from making you blend in.

3

Document your content strategy.

The topics you'll own, channels you'll prioritize, cadence you'll maintain, and the metrics that prove it's working.

4

Then use AI to accelerate execution.

Research, draft, repurpose, and distribute faster than a human team alone could manage.

5

Measure the output.

Qualified leads, discovery calls, content attributed to pipeline. If you can't draw the line, adjust the strategy, not the volume.

71%
vs
23.1%

of Canadian SMBs use AI tools actively, but **fewer than 1 in 4** have built the marketing automation infrastructure to **measure and compound on that activity**.

STATISTICS CANADA • Q2 2025 & MICROSOFT CANADA, 2025

04 What's working, and what isn't

The channel landscape has polarized. A few approaches generate strong, measurable returns. A larger number generate activity that feels productive but doesn't show up in pipeline. The difference is not budget — **it is clarity, targeting, and consistency.**

Not working

Cold outreach at scale

Mass connection requests and spray-and-pray sequences have crossed a threshold where the signal-to-noise ratio has collapsed. Outbound works when it leads with specific, genuine value and targets with precision that signals real research. A message referencing a company's recent expansion or published content **outperforms a generic pitch tenfold.**

Working

Account-Based Marketing

ABM delivers the most reliable results we see for companies willing to commit properly. Not personalized emails to a target list; a coordinated, multi-channel program built around specific verticals or roles with high propensity to buy.

Working

Founder-led LinkedIn

Not the company page, the individual. A founder with 2,000 well-targeted connections in their vertical can generate meaningful awareness and inbound without meaningful paid spend, provided they're consistent and substantive.

Working

Depth over volume in content

A 2,000-word article that answers a real question with specific data and a clear point of view beats ten 500-word posts anyone could have written. That standard is a durable competitive advantage.

\$200K+

in gross profit generated within six months from a single ABM program for a Canadian cybersecurity client.

MRGE MARKETING CLIENT ENGAGEMENT • 2025–2026

That result came from a vertical or role specific ABM program targeting a defined set of high-fit accounts — research-led outreach, vertical content, a targeted event presence, and a channel-partner component. No single element drove it. **The coordination across channels did.**

From 2024 status to 2026 reality

APPROACH	2024 STATUS	2026 REALITY
Volume cold outreach	Declining returns	Largely ineffective, noise floor too high
Generic LinkedIn content	Inconsistent results	Invisible, buyers & algorithm deprioritize it
Founder-led LinkedIn	Emerging advantage	The single highest-ROI organic channel
ABM (multi-channel)	Underutilized	Fastest path to measurable new revenue
Depth-first content	Differentiator	Table stakes for AI search visibility
Marketing automation	Nice to have	Required for attribution and scale

05 The pattern we see before we get involved

There is a version of this story many clients bring to the table. It does not matter whether the company is a professional services firm in Toronto or a technology company in Calgary. **The pattern is nearly identical.**

They are active. They have a LinkedIn presence; maybe the founder posts occasionally. They have a website. They might be running ads or working with a freelance content writer. By most appearances, they are doing marketing.

But when we ask the diagnostic questions – where did your last five clients come from, what's your budget as a percentage of revenue, what metrics are you tracking – the answers reveal the real situation. **No attribution. No measurement. No documented strategy connecting activity to outcome.** The marketing exists, but it does not add up to anything.



We call it the Campaign Treadmill. The activity feels productive. The channels are being managed. But there's no compound effect, no inbound building, no pipeline you can point to and say: marketing drove that. The treadmill keeps moving. The business stays in the same place.

Melissa Gallo · Founder & CEO, mrge Marketing

What changes, and how fast

The timeline for results follows a consistent pattern across our client base:

3 months Immediate improvements across existing channels, better engagement, more qualified conversations, clearer attribution. Some clients see new leads simply because targeting and messaging have sharpened.

6 months The effect compounds. Content builds authority, LinkedIn presence grows, inbound appears with regularity, and the measurement system shows what's generating return. The right point to layer in targeted outbound or paid.

12 months A regular inbound channel, not dependent on constant outbound or paid spend to sustain it. Built on content, presence, and reputation accumulated over the year. Paid and outbound now amplify what already works.

**12
months**

Typical timeline to a functioning, regular inbound channel for a Canadian B2B company starting from a defined foundation.

MRGE MARKETING CLIENT DATA · 2024–2026

06 What to expect & plan for: H2 2026

The second half of 2026 will separate the companies that have been building from the companies that have been performing. Here is our honest assessment of what's coming.

A Budget scrutiny will intensify

The "do more with less" mandate is not going away. For companies that can't attribute spend to pipeline, this means cuts. Building that capability is the highest-priority investment for Q3 2026, it's a business problem, not a marketing one.

B The content quality gap will widen

The crowded middle of decent, generic content gets squeezed from both ends. Companies that invested in genuine depth will see it compound; those that treated AI as a content factory will find their library large but invisible.

C ABM will accelerate as the preferred revenue model

As broad-based approaches get harder, ABM is continuing to be the dominant model for companies serious about growth. Build functioning ABM programs in Q3 and you'll be materially stronger by Q4.

D Knowing what great looks like will become the differentiator

The companies that stand out in H2 2026 aren't producing the most content, they're the ones with the leadership to set a standard and hold the team to it. Whether it's a fractional CMO, an internal leader, or a trusted external partner, someone needs to be accountable for what great looks like.

What to do right now

Four diagnostic questions. Wherever the first "no" lands is your first priority.

Can you attribute your last five new clients to a specific channel?

If not, **measurement** is your first priority.

Do you have a documented ICP (industry, size, role, triggers, objections)?

If not, **strategy foundation** is your first priority.

Do you have a publishing cadence you can sustain for twelve months without heroics?

If not, **infrastructure** is your first priority.

Is someone accountable for marketing outcomes, with authority and a revenue target?

If not, **leadership** is your first priority.

If you answered yes to all the above: are you running any form of account-based or vertical-focused marketing?

If not, **ABM** is your next priority.

If ABM is already in motion: how mature is your personalization?

If it's mostly email, **depth and channel coordination** is your next priority.

Focus is a significant advantage.

The Canadian B2B market in 2026 is not forgiving of vague strategy. Buyers are more informed, more self-directed, and more efficient at filtering out vendors who haven't earned their attention. None of that is reason for pessimism — it is reason for clarity.

The companies that will compound through the second half of this year stopped trying to be everywhere and started building something durable: **a defined audience, a consistent presence, a measurement system, and a strategic owner.** That is not a complex formula. But in a market flooded with activity and short on accountability, it is a focused one.

Want an honest assessment of where you stand?

Let's chat about your marketing program for 2026 and beyond.

[Book a discovery call](#)

Methodology & sources

All statistics are drawn from named, verifiable sources. Canada-specific data is identified as such; where global or North American data is applied to the Canadian context, the source and scope are noted. First-person observations from mrge Marketing are clearly marked and drawn from active client engagements.

IAB Canada	2025 Internet Advertising Revenue Survey & Forecast. iabcanada.com
Statistics Canada	AI use by businesses in Canada, Q2 2025 · Marketing technology & automation adoption, Q2 2025. statcan.gc.ca
Microsoft Canada / Edelman	Majority of Canadian SMBs Embrace AI — survey of 300 SMB decision-makers, January 2025 . news.microsoft.com/source/canada
Gartner	B2B Buyer Experience Research, 2025 · AI in B2B Purchasing Research, 2025. gartner.com
Forrester	B2B Marketing Budget Benchmarks & Pipeline Research, 2025–2026. forrester.com
Corporate Visions	B2B Buying Behavior Statistics & Trends, 2025. corporatevisions.com
Content Marketing Inst.	B2B Content Marketing Trends Research, 2025 . contentmarketinginstitute.com
BDC	Average Marketing Budget for a Small Business. bdc.ca
mrge Marketing	Direct client engagement observations, 2024–2026. mrgemarketing.com

ABOUT MRGE MARKETING

We build the marketing engine your business deserves and we run it.

mrge Marketing is a Canadian B2B marketing agency offering fractional CMO leadership and full marketing execution for growing professional services and technology companies.

We uniquely offer fractional CMO strategy with a full execution team — SEO, content, LinkedIn, email, events, and demand generation — all under one roof so there are no gap between the strategy and the work.

Fractional CMO

Marketing as a Service

Custom Projects